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The Sunday EXPRESS



EYE

Wind in her Hair

Women in India are riding further, faster and in greater numbers. What holds them together is the sense of community, not choosing just a destination but a direction

SCREEN

At his centenary celebrations,
unpacking Uttam Kumar's appeal



DAILY FROM: AHMEDABAD, CHANDIGARH, DELHI, JAIPUR, KOLKATA, LUCKNOW, MUMBAI, NAGPUR, PATNA, PUNE, VADODARA

AMID ROW OVER OBJECTIONS BY ELECTION COMMISSIONERS TO SIR-RELATED DECISIONS AND GAPS IN PROCESSES

Disquiet within, all three Election Commissioners meet, take first steps

Unmapped voters need not attend hearings, ECINet to get a review

Damini Nath
New Delhi, September 26

IN ITS first meeting since *The Indian Express* reported on the deep divide within the Election Commission over the past 10 months, the poll panel on Saturday sought to address several concerns raised by its two commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi.

Electors who were issued notices for “logical discrepancies” and for being “unmapped” in the ongoing Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls will not be required to attend hearings to establish their eligibility, a statement issued by the ECI said.

This exemption from in-person hearings will be a relief to lakhs of electors who were issued notices in the ongoing SIR. The decision comes as

hearings are being held across states on the basis of system-generated notices.

“Unmapped” voters are those whose names did not figure in the rolls of the previous intensive revision, and who were unable to provide the names of their parents or grandparents too during that revision. “Logical discrepancies” refers to certain discrepancies flagged by the ECI’s centralised software based on which voters are issued notices following which they need to submit additional documentary proof to stay in the rolls.

“In case of any person to whom notice has been issued during the ongoing SIR, for being unmapped and logical discrepancies, BLOs will visit the homes of such persons for collection of documents and thereafter upload them on the



CEC Gyanesh Kumar with ECs Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi in New Delhi, Saturday. X/@ECISVEEP

• KEY DECISIONS BY COMMISSION

CONCERNS ON ECINET: Centralisation of electoral rolls; Officers backed by law not getting proper access to ERONet

ECI: A committee headed by Sr Deputy Election Commissioner and including an independent expert will review the ECINET

CONCERN ON 'LOGICAL DISCREPANCIES': ECI filing appeals against voters who were first flagged for 'logical discrepancies'

by it, but then included by judicial officers in the SIR.

ECI: BLOs will visit homes to collect documents from those issued notices during ongoing SIR for being unmapped and for logical discrepancies, and upload them on ECINET for decision by ERO

CONCERN ON 'ADDITION TO FORM 6': Additions to Form 6 linking new voter registration to SIR is 'illegal, unauthorised'. Cannot be

made unless govt amends rules.

ECI: For non-SIR period, the forms applicable as per Rules (the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960) will be used

CONCERNS ON issues such as conduct of meetings, permissions, directions by Commission

ECI: Agenda will be circulated in advance and minutes will be issued for all Commission meetings; all directions issued by the Commissioners to officers shall be complied with

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'WISHY-WASHY' NOTE IS DAMAGE CONTROL, SAYS CONGRESS

BJP RALLIES BEHIND EC: 'RAHUL SHOULD EXPLAIN WHY HE LIED'

ECINET, for decision by the ERO. Such persons need not be called for hearing to ERO/AERO office. Only in exceptional circumstances, as decided by the ERO, the hearing will be held preferably online. Any adult member of the family can be authorised by the elector to attend the hearing on their behalf, if required,” the EC announced.

The Commission, comprising Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, and ECs Sandhu and Joshi, held a meeting at 3pm on Saturday, the EC statement said. It underlined that the press note had the “approval of the full Commission” and released a photo of the three-member EC at the meeting.

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Maharashtra declares drought in 75% of state amid rainfall deficit

Alok Deshpande
& Shubhangi Khapre
Mumbai, September 26

WITH MAHARASHTRA recording a rainfall deficit of 18% this year, the state government on Saturday declared drought in 265 of the state's 358 tehsils—about three-fourths of Maharashtra.

The declaration, under the Drought Management Code, 2016, will trigger crop-loss surveys and a package of immediate concessions, including waiver of land revenue, restructuring of crop loans, a stay on recovery of agriculture-related loans and relaxation of Viksit



A farmer in Mukhed, Nanded district. HAFIZKHAN PATHAN

Bharat-Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) (VB-G RAM G) norms. Financial assistance for crop losses

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All three Commissioners meet

In its statement, the Commission also said that a declaration that was added without amendment to the voter enrolment form or Form 6, would go back to the original after the SIR. *The Indian Express* had reported that the two ECs had said this addition was “illegal, unauthorised” and called for its removal so that young, first-time voters are not harassed.

Responding to some specific concerns, the EC said agendas would be circulated in advance for all commission meetings and minutes issued. The Annual Performance Appraisal Reports of officers would be completed within the stipulated time frame, which is by December 31 each year, and that the commission’s approval will be taken for foreign trips of the officers. Further, in its statement, the EC said, “All directions issued by the Commissioners to the officers of the Commission shall be meticulously complied with.”

The EC also clarified that the Form 6, which is the statutory form for new voter enrolment, would revert to the original one

as per the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960. Earlier this year, the EC had added a declaration to the online Form 6 that requires applicants to answer if they or their parents/grandparents were on the rolls of the previous intensive revision of electoral rolls. While a separate declaration form was created by the EC for the SIR, the declaration was inserted within the online version of the Form 6, which can only be amended by the Law Ministry. The two Election Commissioners had raised concerns with the same.

“The declaration attached to Form 6 for SIR has been upheld by the Hon’ble Supreme Court. For non-SIR period, the Forms applicable as per Rules (the Registration of Electors Rules 1960) will be used,” the EC said in its statement.

The two ECs, Sandhu and Joshi, had also flagged concerns with the centralisation of the ECINet portal. The EC on Saturday announced the setting up of a committee to review ECINet and double-check if it complies with the law. “Field officers have

role-based access to the ECINet system as per their statutory powers. A Committee headed by Sr. Deputy Election Commissioner (DEC) and including an independent expert from ITI/IIT will review the ECINet to double-check that it complies with the provisions of the Acts and Rules and submit report to the Commission,” it said.

According to the statement, various upgradations of the portal have already been made based on the inputs from State CEOs in the past few months. “In case, any further flexibility is required by the field officers, that will be made operational. Henceforth, all the new initiatives about IT modules and portals will be discussed in the Committee of Officers (COO) before approval by the Commission,” it said.

The EC said that the letters written by the two ECs to Cabinet Secretary T V Somanathan were in relation to the conduct of an officer. “The letter to Cabinet Secretary was not related to any policy matter of the Commission or IT division but related to the working of an officer on

deputation to ECI. The work re-distribution orders issued by the concerned officer were not actually implemented after the orders of the two Commissioners and the oversight over the IT division by the DEC was never actually withdrawn,” the EC statement read.

With regard to the ongoing SIR, which has been completed in 20 states/UTs so far, the EC said: “Any person whose name has got left out during SIR or thereafter, and any person including young/first-time voter, may apply to the concerned ERO, for inclusion of their names in the electoral rolls under the process of continuous updation. CEOs have been directed to facilitate the same. The CEOs, DEOs, EROs will immediately launch a special drive for enrolment of these electors.”

Regarding the issue of 97 Goa electors who had been deleted from the final roll despite the statutory officials recommending their inclusion during the SIR earlier this year, the EC said the Chief Electoral Officer of Goa had directed the Booth Level Officers concerned to collect enrolment forms from them, and 81 of those electors had already filled the Form 6.

Maharashtra drought

will be decided separately after the assessment is completed, government officials said.

The declaration comes as the state enters the final days of the monsoon with a significant rainfall deficit. From June 1 to September 26, Maharashtra has received 798.2 mm of rainfall against a normal 970.9 mm, a deficit of 18%. Except for five districts, the state has recorded deficient rainfall during the period.

The situation is particularly acute in Marathwada, where the eight districts together have recorded a 38% deficit. It ranges from 16% in Chhatrapati Sambhajnagar to 48% in Hingoli.

In Vidarbha, the average deficit across 11 districts is 27%, with the shortfall ranging from 26% in Yavatmal to 42% in Amravati.

The state government’s decision follows a report by the Agriculture Commissioner, which found drought-like conditions from June onwards in 265 tehsils based on rainfall deficiency and other factors. The first trigger under the drought assessment process, which includes a continuous dry spell of at least 21 days without significant rainfall during the monsoon, has been found applicable in these areas.

Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis, who recently toured parts of the state to assess the drought situation and met farmers, said the government’s focus would be on providing relief to those affected.

“In this drought-like situation, farmers, agricultural labourers and working people in the state are at the centre of our relief efforts. All possible measures will be taken to provide them relief. We stand firmly with our farmer brothers and sisters. Let us make united efforts to overcome this challenge,” Fadnavis said.

He also directed the Revenue and Agriculture departments and other agencies to begin field-level assessments immediately and coordinate to ensure that relief reaches farmers.

The 265 affected tehsils are spread across all six revenue divisions. They include 49 tehsils in Nashik division, 35 in Pune division, 74 in Chhatrapati Sambhajnagar division, 56 in Amravati division and 39 in Nag-

pur division. In the Thane division, 12 tehsils have been included.

The government’s declaration does not immediately determine the crop compensation individual farmers will receive. District administrations will first conduct panchnamas and document the condition of crops with the help of photographs and GPS coordinates. The reports will be submitted through the Agriculture Commissioner, following which the government will issue a separate order on assistance.

Relief measures

For farmers and rural households, the immediate relief measures announced with the drought declaration include a waiver of land revenue, restructuring of crop loans and a stay on recovery of agriculture-related loans. The government has also provided for concessions on electricity bills for agricultural pumps, with bills for pumps up to 7.5 HP already waived and concessions to apply to pumps above that capacity.

Other measures include a waiver of examination fees for school and college students, relaxation of VB–GRAM G norms to maximise employment, deployment of tankers for drinking water wherever required, no disconnection of electricity supply to agricultural pumps in villages declared to be facing shortages, and arrangements for food-grains and fodder.

The measures are intended to provide immediate relief while the crop-loss assessment is carried out. The extent of compensation to individual farmers will depend on the findings of the surveys and the separate government order to be issued on crop damage assistance.

Maharashtra Congress chief Harshvardhan Sapkal said the government had announced concessions but no substantial financial assistance for farmers. “The important question is when will farmers get compensation. First deposit cash into their bank accounts and then complete the formalities of panchnama and surveys,” he said, demanding Rs 1 lakh per hectare for crop losses, free seeds and fertilisers for the rabi season, and immediate arrangements for fodder and drinking water.

RISING POWER DEMAND TRIGGERS EMERGENCY MEASURES

Captive coal plants asked to run at full capacity from Oct 1

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, September 26

AMID RISING power demand, the Centre on Friday invoked emergency mechanisms to issue directions to about 112 captive coal-fired power plants to operate at maximum capacity from October 1 till December 31. The country is witnessing an unusual surge in electricity demand this September, with peak power demand nearing the level recorded during peak summer. On September 10, the country's peak power demand touched 269 gigawatt (GW), the highest-ever peak demand recorded for the month. So far, the peak power demand for the year was 270 GW which was recorded during the peak summer in May.

A captive power plant is a dedicated power-generation facility which is built and operated by an industrial company or a group of factories primarily to supply electricity for their own use, rather than selling power to the public grid.

The direction has been issued under Section 11 of the Electricity Act, which allows the government to mandate power generation in extraordinary circumstances.

The directive is applicable to all coal-based captive power plants with 50 megawatt capacity and above which will be required to "operate and generate power to the maximum extent of their available capacity."

"The generators shall offer their available surplus generation, after meeting their own captive demand, through the power exchanges, in accordance



India is witnessing an unusual surge in electricity demand this September, nearing peak summer levels. REUTERS

with the applicable market regulations and procedures," it read.

The government said the move was aimed at maximising electricity availability. "Entire capacity of all the sources of generating electricity including the captive generating plants" needs to be utilised to the maximum possible extent, it said, asking the generators to maintain adequate coal stock to ensure availability of fuel for operation of the plant and enable maximum generation.

"The generators shall submit a weekly report to the Central Electricity Authority indicating generation, captive consumption and sale of power through the power exchanges/other permitted avenues, along with details of available capacity and coal stock, as may be prescribed," it added.

Separately, the power ministry also extended the same emergency mechanism to Tata Power's imported coal-based plant, Coastal Gujarat Power Ltd, till December 31.

Notably, the plant has been running under this provision since March, and it was slated to end this month.

Before March, the 4 GW capacity plant had remained largely idle for nearly six months due to high fuel costs and the absence of a viable power purchase arrangement. Earlier this year, the Gujarat government also gave approval of a revised power purchase arrangement with the plant, clearing the way for the resumption of long-term supply from the plant.

A senior government official said the emergency provision was extended only to Tata Power's plant, as other imported coal-based plants were operational and were not facing any challenges.

The invocation of the emergency provisions is not unprecedented. The government has invoked it in previous years during peak summer months to ensure adequate power supply.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Net FDI inflows surge to \$7.3 bn in July, highest since May 2021

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, September 26

AMID CONTINUED pressure on the external front due to changes in the global investment environment and better opportunities elsewhere, India saw a jump in net foreign direct investment (FDI) inflows in July, with data released late Friday by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) showing that it soared to an over five-year high of \$7.35 billion. This is the highest monthly inflow since May 2021's \$8.80 billion.

On a gross basis, FDI in July was \$14.58 billion, the third-highest in the last six years.

Compared to July 2025, the latest net and gross FDI figures are up 64% and 24%, respectively.

The latest FDI print comes even as the government warns of challenges on the external front, with Chief Economic Advisor V Anantha Nageswaran cautioning on Friday that "even if even if we tick (all the) boxes", money may not flow in immediately.

"You can do everything right, the public will see that there is no result, and will therefore be clamouring for more. But the point is global context has shifted," Nageswaran had said at an event, adding that higher global interest rates, among other factors, were key factors.

The government and the RBI have tried to encourage foreign inflows in the last four months, with the concessional swap window for Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank) de-

posits turning out to be overwhelmingly successful. However, the rupee is not too far away from its all-time low of 96.96 per dollar. It closed at 95.82 on Friday.

"Communication, financial and computer services were the major sectors, receiving more than four-fifths of the equity inflows," the RBI said in its monthly State of the Economy article. "Mauritius, the UAE, and the US were the major source countries, accounting for about 70% of equity inflows."

For the first four months of 2026-27, net FDI inflows amounted to \$13.43 billion, up 38% from the same period last year. Meanwhile, gross FDI was 13% higher at \$43.85 billion.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Centre notifies 2 offshore mineral blocks near Great Nicobar

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, September 26

THE MINISTRY of Mines has notified two more offshore mineral blocks near Great Nicobar Island in the Andaman Sea, covering a combined area of 1,632 square kilometres, for grant of composite licences for polymetallic nodules and crusts.

A composite licence requires the successful bidder to undertake further exploration and establish the mineral potential of the block before proceeding to mining operations.

The two blocks are West Sewell Ridge-01, off Great Nicobar Island, covering 1,000 square kilometres, and Sewell Rise-01, in the southern part of Sewell Rise near Great Nicobar Island, covering 632 square kilometres.

Polymetallic nodules and crusts are seabed mineral deposits containing metals such as nickel, cobalt, manganese, copper and rare earth elements.

The latest notification comes after the ministry failed to auction seven offshore mineral blocks containing the same minerals in the same area during the country's first-ever auction of offshore mineral blocks.

In November 2024, the ministry had put 13 offshore mineral blocks up for auction for grant of composite licences, including seven blocks near Great Nicobar Island.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

● ON OCTOBER 1, GOOGLE IS SET TO LAUNCH AN EXPERIMENTAL SATELLITE INTO ORBIT THAT WILL HAVE ENOUGH COMPUTING POWER TO ANSWER SIMPLE A.I. QUERIES FROM SPACE

As AI’s energy needs grow, Google takes the data centre race to outer space

Kate Conger & Cade Metz
San Francisco, September 26

AT A lab in San Francisco last month, a team of technicians in protective suits and hairnets poked, prodded and inspected a refrigerator-size satellite commissioned by Google.

First, they examined the satellite’s solar panels, which would unfurl in space and face the sun. The satellite was then placed on a table and shaken rapidly in a vibration test, to see whether the chips inside would be damaged or the machine would come apart during a journey into space. The technicians painstakingly painted a small line over each screw to

help indicate any loosening during the shaking.

The satellite passed the vibration test, with its screws staying put and the chips remaining intact. James Manyika, Google’s senior vice president for research, called the results “great,” but he said he still wondered what would happen when the satellite went to space.

The work was part of an ambitious effort from Google called Project Suncatcher, which aims to put artificial intelligence data centers into space and to harness the sun’s energy to power them. On October 1, the satellite from the San Francisco lab — which Google has named MVP — is set to become the first step toward

that goal by a major tech company. It will be loaded onto a SpaceX Falcon 9 rocket at the Vandenberg Space Force Base near Santa Barbara, California, and then launched into orbit.

Google provided *The New York Times* with the first inside look at the project, which seemed like a science-fiction dream just a year ago.

Elon Musk, Jeff Bezos, Sam Altman and others have pledged support for orbital data centers, but the idea faces many challenges, including withstanding radiation in space and the costs of getting machines beyond the atmosphere. Yet as data centers grapple with terrestrial opposition and physical li-



The satellite’s solar panels will unfurl once it is in orbit, collecting energy to power Google’s AI chips. NYT

mits, having computing facilities float above Earth has become increasingly attractive.

To be clear, Google is not

sending up a full data center — only an experimental precursor to one. MVP contains four specialized computer chips

called “tensor processing units,” which have the computing power of one server in a data center. The satellite’s solar panels will supply only about one kilowatt of power — roughly the amount needed to run a hair dryer — to the chips.

But that will be enough for Google to test its hardware against the harsh conditions of space. The satellite will answer simple AI queries and operate for a year, though it is set to circle Earth for up to six years. Eventually, it is expected to succumb to Earth’s gravitational pull and burn up as it descends through the atmosphere.

Manyika said Google’s expectations for the satellite were

tempered. “We don’t expect, to be perfectly frank, that we’ll have anything usefully operational in the next few years,” he said, comparing the mission to the company’s early efforts to build driverless cars. “Remember how Google was researching for like 15 years, before anything showed up? I think this is going to look like that.”

Expanding from one satellite to a vast network of them that operates like a giant data center will take years and enormous funds, said Brandon Lucia, a professor of electrical and computer engineering at Carnegie Mellon University.

“If you do this on a large scale, there are additional en-

gineering problems,” he said. “That is uncharted waters.”

Project Suncatcher was the brainchild of Blaise Agüera y Arcas, 51, a Google vice president and AI researcher who leads a team studying intelligence. About three years ago, he attended a gathering of entrepreneurs and AI researchers where the main topic was the escalating energy needs of AI systems. Agüera y Arcas left the event convinced that data centers needed to move to space to harness solar power.

The idea “has been on my mind since I was kid,” he said. “There are longstanding ideas in science fiction about using stars for computation.” NYT